

Alberta Housing Crisis Report

No Rent Cap. No Affordable Housing. No Way Out.

A documented analysis of the housing situation facing 79,000 AISH recipients in the only major Canadian province with no legislated rent cap.

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — April 2026 Report Series

Three simultaneous blows to AISH recipients in 2025–2026: the federal Canada Disability Benefit clawed back by Alberta — \$200/month gone. Community housing rent increased by \$221/month — a 63% increase via ministerial order. ADAP transition cuts \$200/month from January 2028. Combined: up to \$621/month removed from people whose income was already insufficient to cover housing. In a province with no rent cap.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Alberta's housing market is the least protected rental environment in Canada. There is no legislated limit on how much a landlord can increase rent. There is no meaningful provincial affordable housing supply pipeline. Wait lists for subsidized community housing in Edmonton and Calgary now exceed 10,000 and 6,500 applicants respectively — and they are growing faster than units become available.

For Albertans on AISH — receiving \$1,940 per month in 2026 — the housing situation is not difficult. It is mathematically impossible. Average Alberta rent exceeds the entire AISH living allowance. And the small number of AISH recipients who do access subsidized community housing just had their rent increased by 63% through a cabinet order signed without public consultation.

SECTION 1: NO RENT CAP — ALBERTA STANDS ALONE

Alberta is the only major province in Canada with no legislated limit on how much a landlord can increase rent. Landlords may increase rent by any amount, provided they give 90 days' written notice and wait at least 12 months since the last increase. There is no ceiling, no review process, and no mechanism by which a tenant can challenge the amount of an increase.

PROVINCE	RENT CAP (2025)	RENT CAP (2026)	AISH RECIPIENT PROTECTED?
British Columbia	3.0%	2.3%	Yes

PROVINCE	RENT CAP (2025)	RENT CAP (2026)	AISH RECIPIENT PROTECTED?
Ontario	2.5%	2.5%	Yes
Quebec	~5.9% (regulated)	Regulated	Yes
Nova Scotia	5.0%	Regulated	Yes
Manitoba	Regulated	Regulated	Yes
Alberta	NO CAP — unlimited	NO CAP — unlimited	NO

Sources: Province of BC Residential Tenancy Branch; SOSCHIP, January 2025; Ontario Ministry of Municipal Affairs and Housing.

- Alberta experienced a 17.5% year-over-year increase in average listed rent prices in 2024 — among the highest in Canada. (Urbanation/Rentals.ca, June 2024)
- Half of the 75 Alberta municipalities surveyed reported average rent increases of 10% or more in 2024. One municipality recorded a 37% single-year jump. (CMHC/Great West Media, December 2024)
- Average rent for a three-bedroom unit in Alberta reached \$2,138/month in 2024 — up 21.3% year-over-year. (GIL Property Management, 2024)
- Edmonton's average rent across all unit types rose approximately 26% between October 2021 and August 2025. (Statistics Canada CPI data, CBC News, October 2025)

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR AISH: The 2026 AISH living allowance is \$1,940/month. Average Alberta 1-bedroom rent is \$1,500–\$1,900+/month — leaving a single recipient as little as \$40 after rent before food or utilities. 86% of AISH recipients are single individuals. For single parents requiring three bedrooms, average Alberta rent of \$2,138/month already exceeds the entire AISH payment. In a province with no rent cap, this gap widens every year without any legislative protection.

SECTION 2: THE COMMUNITY HOUSING RENT INCREASE — A 63% HIKE BY MINISTERIAL ORDER

Community housing was the only housing option where AISH recipients had any protection. Under the previous system, \$735 of the AISH monthly benefit was exempted from the income calculation used to set rent. This kept rents at approximately 17% of AISH income — survivable, if barely.

On May 15, 2025, Minister Jason Nixon signed an Order in Council removing that exemption. Beginning October 1, 2025, rent in community housing for AISH recipients is calculated at 30% of total income — with no AISH exemption.

METRIC	BEFORE OCT 1, 2025	AFTER OCT 1, 2025
AISH income used to calculate rent	\$1,166/month (after \$735 exemption)	\$1,901/month (full amount)
Rent charged (30% of eligible income)	\$349/month	\$570/month
Rent as % of total AISH benefit	~17%	~30%
Year-over-year rent increase	—	63% increase
Notice provided to disability advocates	None	Zero consultation

Sources: CBC News, July 9, 2025; Inclusion Alberta media release, July 16, 2025; Civida — SHAR FAQ, July 2025.

COMING NEXT — CHILD BENEFITS AS INCOME: Starting January 1, 2027, the Canada Child Benefit and Alberta Child and Family Benefit will be included as income when calculating Rent Assistance Benefit amounts. Starting January 1, 2028, these benefits will also be counted as income for community housing rent. For single parents of children with severe disabilities, whose Canada Child Benefit is absorbed entirely by their children's medical and care costs, this change treats designated child support as personal income available for housing. It is not.

2.1 Cumulative Income Loss — Stacked

INCOME IMPACT STACKED	MONTHLY AMOUNT
CDB clawback (from July 2025)	–\$200/month
Community housing rent increase (from Oct 2025)	–\$221/month
ADAP benefit cut (from January 2028)	–\$200/month
TOTAL cumulative loss — community housing AISH recipient (from Jan 2028)	–\$621/month
AISH living allowance 2026	\$1,940/month
Remaining after all three losses (from Jan 2028)	\$1,319/month — before any other expense

*\$1,319/month before food, transportation, medications, and clothing — for a person assessed by the provincial government as permanently unable to earn a living. **This is not a projection. It is the documented result of three separate policy decisions made by the Government of Alberta in 2025.***

SECTION 3: THE AFFORDABLE HOUSING WAITLIST — YEARS, NOT MONTHS

Community housing is theoretically the solution for AISH recipients who cannot afford private market rent. It is not a functioning solution. Waitlists in Alberta's two major cities are measured in thousands of applicants. Average wait times are years. And the waitlist is not first-come, first-served — priority is assessed by need, meaning a person can wait for years and still be displaced by a higher-priority applicant.

3.1 Edmonton — Civida Waitlist

METRIC	FIGURE	SOURCE
Total applicants on Civida waitlist	More than 10,000 (October 2025)	Civida statement, CBC News, October 2025
Waitlist in March 2023	7,260 applicants	Civida, cited by CBC News
Waitlist growth	+2,740+ applicants in approximately 2.5 years	Calculated from above
New applicants per month	Approximately 700	Civida statement, October 2025
Civida units housing AISH recipients	16% of current tenants have AISH as primary income	Civida, July 2025

Source: CBC News — “For some low-income families in Edmonton, the wait for affordable housing lasts years.” October 20, 2025.

3.2 Calgary — Calgary Housing Company Waitlist

METRIC	FIGURE	SOURCE
Total applicants eligible and on waitlist	More than 6,500 (2024)	Calgary Housing Company applicant portal
Calgary Housing units managed	More than 9,200 units — housing over 27,000 people	Calgary Housing Company, May 2024

METRIC	FIGURE	SOURCE
Average age of Calgary Housing properties	~40 years old	CEO Sarah Woodgate, CBC News, May 2024
Wait list system	Not first-come, first-served — priority changes daily based on assessed need	Calgary Housing Company
Can Calgary Housing predict when a unit will be offered?	No — explicitly stated on application documentation	Calgary Housing application guide

Sources: Calgary Housing Company application documentation; CBC News — May 15, 2024.

WHAT THE WAITLIST MEANS IN PRACTICE: An AISH recipient who applies to Civiida's waitlist today joins more than 10,000 households ahead of them, with 700 new applicants arriving every month. There is no defined wait time. Priority can change at any time — a higher-need applicant can be inserted ahead regardless of wait. There is no functional safety net for someone facing a private-market eviction or a 30% rent increase next month.

SECTION 4: THE INCOME-TO-RENT MATH

Scenario A: Single AISH Recipient, Private Rental (1 BR)

	MONTHLY AMOUNT	SOURCE
AISH living allowance (2026)	\$1,940	Government of Alberta
Average 1-bedroom rent — Edmonton/Calgary area	\$1,500–\$1,900+	CMHC 2024; rising with no cap
Remaining after rent (best case)	\$40–\$440	Calculated
Groceries (single adult, 2026)	\$800–\$1,000	Canada Food Price Report 2026
Utilities (electricity, gas, internet)	\$385–\$510	Alberta utility estimates
RESULT	DEFICIT of \$750–\$1,500+/month	Housing + food + utilities alone exceed income

Scenario B: Single Parent with Children, Private Rental (3 BR)

	MONTHLY AMOUNT	SOURCE
AISH living allowance (2026)	\$1,940	Government of Alberta
Canada Child Benefit (3 children, approx.)	\$2,473	CRA — designated for children's costs
Total household income	~\$4,413	Before any expenses
Average 3-bedroom rent — Alberta 2024	\$2,138+	CMHC/Urbanation 2024
Remaining after rent	\$2,275 or less	For all other costs
Groceries (family of 4, special dietary needs)	\$1,200–\$1,500+	CFPR 2026; higher for sensory dietary restrictions
Utilities	\$385–\$510	Alberta utility estimates
Transportation (no vehicle)	\$200–\$400+	Ride services
CCB designated for children's medical/care costs	Absorbed entirely	Not surplus — covers children's care
RESULT	Operating at deficit or bare minimum	No buffer, no savings, no capacity to absorb rent increases

Note: Canada Child Benefit is income designated for children's costs — food, clothing, medical supplies, therapies. For families with children with complex medical needs, this benefit is not disposable income. It is consumed by the documented costs of caring for these children.

Scenario C: AISH Recipient in Community Housing (Post-October 2025)

	BEFORE OCT 1, 2025	AFTER OCT 1, 2025	CHANGE
AISH living allowance	\$1,901	\$1,940 (2026 rate)	+\$39
Community housing rent	\$349	\$570	+\$221
Net after rent	\$1,552	\$1,370	–\$182
After CDB clawback (\$200)	\$1,352	\$1,170	Further reduced
After ADAP cut (from Jan 2028)	\$1,152	\$970	Further reduced

SECTION 5: THE DISABILITY HOUSING TRAP

AISH program rules create a structural disincentive to cohabitation that directly compounds housing unaffordability. Under current AISH policy, the income of any person sharing a household with an AISH recipient — including a roommate, partner, or any cohabiting adult — may be assessed as part of the household income calculation and used to reduce benefits.

- An AISH recipient cannot take on a roommate to share housing costs without risking benefit reduction based on the roommate's income — even if the arrangement is purely practical.
- An AISH recipient cannot enter into a romantic relationship that progresses to cohabitation without that person's income being assessed and potentially used to reduce benefits.
- An AISH recipient is structurally incentivized to remain living alone — which maximizes housing cost as a share of income and eliminates one of the most common strategies low-income people use to survive a housing crisis.

*The program designed to support recipients' wellbeing has built into its rules a mechanism that prevents the most common cost-sharing solution to housing unaffordability. **In a province with no rent cap and average rents above the AISH living allowance, recipients are told to manage housing costs alone — and then penalized structurally if they try not to.***

5.1 Community Housing Is Not a Universal Solution

- Ground-floor accessible units suitable for families with children who have elopement risk, mobility requirements, or ASD-related safety needs are severely limited in social housing stock.
- Apartment-style community housing presents significant safety challenges for families with non-verbal children with no stranger-danger awareness, active flight risk, or physical aggression.
- Calgary Housing explicitly notes that applicants who restrict acceptable communities “*may prolong the search*” — but families with children in established schools, with medical specialists, and with service provider relationships cannot arbitrarily relocate without serious harm to continuity of care.

*There is no housing solution currently available to an AISH recipient in Alberta that is both accessible and affordable. Private market rent exceeds income. Community housing wait times are years with no guarantee. The rent cap that would limit private market increases does not exist. **The only option the government offers is to wait — in poverty — for a list that may never reach the person at the bottom.***

SECTION 6: WHAT WE ARE ASKING

To the Government of Alberta

- Legislate a rent increase cap for residential tenancies equivalent to or stronger than comparable Canadian provinces. An unlimited rent increase environment combined with a fixed disability income is a structural guarantee of poverty deepening for every AISH recipient in private housing.
- Reverse or significantly modify the October 2025 community housing rent increase for AISH recipients. The removal of the \$735 AISH exemption added \$221/month to the housing cost of the most financially vulnerable tenants, without consultation.
- Halt the planned expansion of rent calculations to include the Canada Child Benefit and Alberta Child and Family Benefit in 2027 and 2028. These benefits are designated for children's costs — they are not household income available for housing.
- Substantially increase the supply of community housing units accessible to families with complex-needs children — including ground-floor units with secure fencing and proximity to established medical and school services.
- Review the AISH cohabitation rules that prevent recipients from cost-sharing with roommates or partners without benefit reduction.
- Develop a specific housing subsidy stream for AISH recipients that bridges the gap between the AISH living allowance and actual Alberta market rents, indexed to rent increases.

To the Government of Canada

- Condition future federal housing transfer payments on provincial implementation of tenant protection measures including rent increase limits.
- Include Alberta's rental market conditions and AISH recipient housing outcomes in federal poverty reduction reporting.
- Expand the National Housing Strategy to include targeted support for people with disabilities in provinces where the combination of no rent cap and inadequate disability income creates a structural housing crisis.

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The Alberta Disability System Breakdown — Advocate

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